1492

The Pivot of History

On the day Columbus landed in the Americas, the late medieval World stood on the precipice of European imperialism. It was covered by almost 700 *states*, countries with a wide variety of governments, degrees of sovereignty, and forms of territorial control (there are less than 200 today), many invented locally. Beyond them, half of the world was inhabited by politically simpler but culturally rich tribal societies. Over the next century, this geography would be completely transformed by European explorers, conquerors, traders, and missionaries.

Largest Cities

general estimates

Beijing	700,000
Vijayanagar	500,000
Al Qahira (Cairo)	400,000
Hangzhou	250,000
Tabriz	250,000
Constantinople	200,000
Gaur	200,000
Paris	200,000
Ayutthaya	150,000
Guangzhou	150,000
Nanjing	150,000
Cuttack	140,000
Fez	130,000
Xi'an	130,000

Sovereign state
Dependent state
Area of micro-states
Composite state
Uncertain status
Non-state area
Berber Tribe or chiefdom
Land trade route
Water trade route
Exploration route
MUSCOVY
SWEDEN
NORWAY (DENMARK)
KALMAR UNION
DENMARK
LIVONIA
LITHUANIA
POLAND
UNION OF HORODŁO
HUNGARY (BOHEMIA)
HOLY ROMAN EMPIRE
ENGLAND
SCOTLAND
IRISH LORDS
FRANCE
CASTILLE
ARAGON
CASTILLE & ARAGON
PORTUGAL
NAPLES (ARAGON)
PAPAL STATES
OTTOMAN EMPIRE
KAZAN (MUSCOVY)
NOGAI
KAZAKH
SIBIR
OIRATS? (MONGOLIA?)
MONGOLIA
MOGHULISTAN
TURFAN
YARKAND
KARA DEL (CHINA)
AQ QOYUNLU
HERAT
EGYPT
MOROCCO
TLEMCEN
IFRIQIYA
SONGHAI
MALI
JOLOF
BORNU
KANEM
TUNJUR
AÏR
ETHIOPIA
ADAL
AJUURAAN
KONGO
MUTAPA
KILWA
DELHI
BENGAL
BAHMANI
VIJAYANAGARA
ODISHA
GUJARAT
SINDH
MING CHINA
JOSEON
JAPAN
ĐẠI VIỆT
AVA
AYUTTHAYA
LAN XANG
CAMBODIA
MALACCA
BRUNEI
MAJAPAHIT
SUNDA
MEXICA
MAYAN PROVINCES
TAWANTINSUYU (INCA)
QUITO (TAWANTINSUYU)
HAUDENOSAUNEE CONFEDERACY
TU'I TONGA
SAMOA?
KAUAI
O'AHU
MOLOKA'I
MAUI
HAWAI'I
ICELAND (NORWAY)
AZORES (PORTUGAL)
MADEIRA (PORTUGAL)
CABO VERDE (PORTUGAL)
First Voyage of Columbus
Pêro da Covilhã (1487-1492)
Silk Road
Qhapaq Ñan

40 years after Gutenberg's first press, **printing** has taken Europe by storm, with presses appearing in one city after another. 1491-92 sees the first type in Spanish, Cyrillic, and Hebrew.

England has emerged from the Hundred Years War against France and the Wars of the Roses against itself with political stability under Henry Tudor, but less territory and status.

France is slowly transitioning from a feudal hierarchy to a consolidated kingdom, acquiring territory by war and marriage. After relinquishing some of it, Charles VIII will leverage his new strength to invade Italy in 1494.

Ferdinand and Isabella are attempting to unite a dozen kingdoms in **Castille and Aragon**, but their sponsorship of Columbus and their conquest of Granada sets the stage for a global Spanish empire.

4 May 1493: Pope Alexander VI grants Castille & Aragon sovereignty over all lands west of the Azores. The Treaty of Tordesillas in 1494 moves the line further west.

2 Jan 1492: The Emir of Granada surrenders the city to Castille.

Venice controls trade in the eastern Mediterranean through its empire of coastal colonies.

The **Haudenosaunee** or Iroquois have the most state-like polity in the future U.S. and Canada, uniting five tribes with an oral constitution.

The great city of Cahokia has been abandoned and the late **Mississippian Culture** has scattered into regional chiefdoms, but they are still building towns around ceremonial mounds.

The 10-15 **Pueblos** of the upper Rio Grande are not large by global standards, but are likely the closest thing to true cities in North America.

12 Oct 1492: Columbus lands in the New World on the island of Guanahani, which he named San Salvador.

In the Mexica Aztec **Triple Alliance**, Tenochtitlan is becoming dominant over its two neighbors and rapidly expanding an empire of dozens of tributary city-states. Hernán Cortés will conquer it in 1521.

Since the fall of Mayapan in the 1440s, the Post-Classic **Mayan** world has fractured into multiple Kuchkabal (provinces). A few will hold out against Spanish conquest through the 17th Century.

Portugal is solidifying its exploration of coastal Africa into an extractive trade network, which they will soon extend to Asia.

Most European educated elites and mariners accept that the Earth is spherical (an even more widely held belief in the Islamic World but rare in China). Columbus is following the theory of Paolo Toscanelli and others that it is significantly smaller than in reality and that Asia is significantly larger, and has thus found the New World almost exactly where he expected to find Japan; the confusion will persist long enough for both regions to be called the "Indies."

Most Polynesian islands are simple societies, but the **Tongans and Hawaiians** have complex kingdoms.

The Inca have built their empire of **Tawantinsuyu** ("Land of four parts") from their home in the central Andes, connected by an extensive network of roads. It will fall to the Spanish in 1532, but some areas will hold out for decades thereafter.

The **Maghreb** consists of several relatively weak sultanates that will be conquered by the Ottomans and the Saadis in the 1500s.

The **Ottoman** march into Europe has been halted by Croatia, so they will turn their attention south; the **Mamluk Sultanate** in Egypt is currently at the height of its power and wealth, but by the early 1500s it will be in disarray and ripe for conquest.

Aq Qoyunlu appears large and powerful, but this Turkic rule over Persia was a loose confederation that lasted only 40 years before being conquered by Shah Ismail and the Safavids.

The **Songhai Empire** has replaced Mali as the dominant power in West Africa, controlling the trade routes between the gold in the southern kingdoms and the Maghreb in the north. **Bornu, Edo, and Oyo** are just starting their rise to regional prominence, while the **Jolof Empire** will soon disintegrate.

1493: The Portuguese establish a permanent base of operations on the island.

Several kingdoms are shown in the interior of southern and central Africa, but our only evidence is later oral tradition, so it is uncertain whether they were established by 1492.

The **Kilwa Sultanate** controls the east African trade routes of Arab, Persian, and Indian merchants, but will be conquered by the Portuguese in 1513.

12 Mar 1488: The furthest point reached by Bartholemeu Dias in his voyage around the Cape of Good Hope. Vasco de Gama would get to India in 1497.

More than 250 years after the death of Genghis Khan, the remnants of his empire still dominate central Asia, from **Mongolia** to the Timurid Moghul sultanates to the Tatar Khanates of **Crimea, Kazan,** and **Astrakhan**. **Herat** is the cultural and intellectual heart of this realm.

India is a patchwork of Muslim sultanates and Hindu rajyas. In the south, **Vijayanagar** is one of the largest cities in the world; in the north, the Lodi dynasty of **Delhi** is on the rise, but in the 1520s, most of the north will be conquered by Babur to become the Mughal Empire, while Portugal will exert heavy influence in the south.

Islam is the dominant global religion, having been spread by trade and conquest across north, east and west Africa; south, southeast, and central Asia, and into southeastern Europe. The **Christian** reconquest of Spain is the first salvo in its future global spread.

China under the Hongzhi Emperor, 10th of the Ming Dynasty, is most likely the most stable part of the world at this time, with a thriving economy, relative peace with its neighbors, and an extensive internal and external trade network. Even when the Portuguese arrive in 1513, they will have little effect.

The Ashikaga Shogunate in **Japan** has a figurehead emperor and relatively weak shogun in 1492, and is riven by almost constant warfare between the daimyō, clan lords who independently rule their provinces with only nominal loyalty to the empire.

The kingdoms of mainland southeast Asia have risen and fallen for hundreds of years. At the moment, **Ayutthaya** is most powerful and stable, while **Vietnam** is expanding. **Cambodia** is in decline after the abandonment of Angkor Wat, while **Ava** is quickly disintegrating as its former vassals take power.

In the islands of Southeast Asia, the Hindu **Majapahit Empire** has collapsed, fracturing into dozens of small kingdoms. In the next century, the Musllim **Demak Sultanate** will expand across the region in competition with the Portuguese who conquer **Malacca** in 1511.

The small Moluccan Islands, especially **Ternate, Tidore**, and **Banda**, have small populations but great prominence due to their monopoly over extremely valuable spices such as nutmeg and cloves. They are important destinations for Chinese and Islamic traders, and the legendary "Spice Islands" are the primary goal for European explorers, notably the misinformed Columbus.

By 1492, European elites are already fairly familiar with the geography of Asia, largely due to the popular reports of Venetian explorers from the Polos in the 13th Century to Niccolò de' Conti in the 15th. While Venice and Genoa have tapped into Muslim trade networks, Spain and Portugal are eager to establish their own direct sea routes to the "Indies."

A sovereign *state* is typically defined as having:

- A stable identity that can outlast a single ruler
- A government consisting of more than one ruler
- A clearly controlled territory inhabited by citizens or subjects
- Local control over domestic and foreign affairs

This definition leaves many edge cases and gray areas, especially during this period of history. Many *emergent states* only somewhat met these requirements, or our knowledge of their status is uncertain. Feudalism and other forms of hierarchical sovereignty yielded a variety of state-like polities. Fiefdoms, vassals, and other *dependent states* had only partial sovereignty subject to a more powerful suzerain. *Composite states*, such as personal unions, confederations, and some empires, consisted of multiple essentially sovereign states under a ruler or law with a limited role.

In addition, territory was often not as clearly demarcated as it is today. It was very common for a state to have limited, nominal, or disputed control over outlying areas. The boundaries on this map attempt to depict this.

Autumn 2026 Edition
This map, like all history and geography, is a work in progress. Our knowledge of this era is limited in many ways, but there is likely information that we have not yet found. Your corrections, suggestions, contributions, and additional sources are very welcome.

Equal Earth Projection
See https://carto.byu.edu for sources and GIS data

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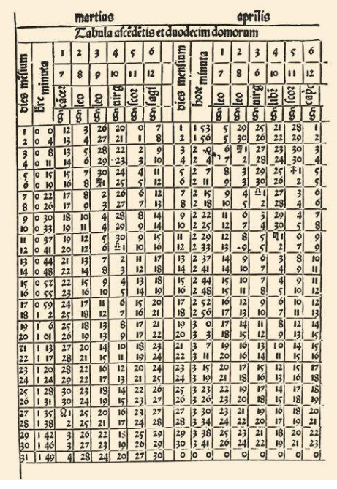
Leonardo da Vinci is in Milan, working on several painting, sculpture, and engineering projects for his patron, Duke Ludivico Sforza. His next masterpiece will be The Last Supper in 1495.
portrait by Francesco Melzi, 1518? >

Holy Roman Emperor **Frederick III** has expanded and consolidated the lands controlled by the Habsburg dynasty, including the Netherlands, to which Burgundy will be added in 1493.
< portrait by Hans Burgkmair, ca1500

Nanak is a young man in the Delhi Sultanate who has a profound spiritual experience around this time, which will soon lead him to found a new religion, Sikhism, as its first guru.
fresco in Baoli Sahib, Goindwal >

Sesshū Tōyō is a master of Japanese ink painting who has merged Chinese styles with Japanese Zen Buddhism to create a distinctively Japanese style of portraits and landscapes.
< self-portrait

Abraham Zacuto is an astronomer whose revolutionary astronomical tables are making Columbus' voyage possible. Expelled from Castille with other Jews, he is now a refugee in Portugal, where he will advise Vasco de Gama and other explorers.
zodiac timing table from *Almanach Perpetuum* >

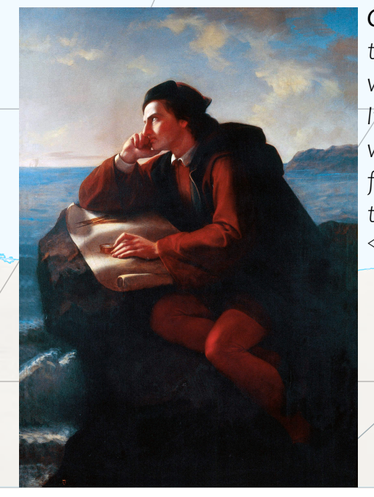


Casimir IV of Poland has brought the Jagiellon dynasty to the height of its power. After he dies in June, his sons are ruling Poland, Lithuania, Bohemia, and Hungary, and several of his daughters are married to other rulers.
< painting by Jan Matejko, ca1893

Kamāl ud-Dīn Behzād is a Persian artist in Herat, known for his detailed miniature illustrations of Islamic stories.
"Yusef and Zuleykha," 1488 >

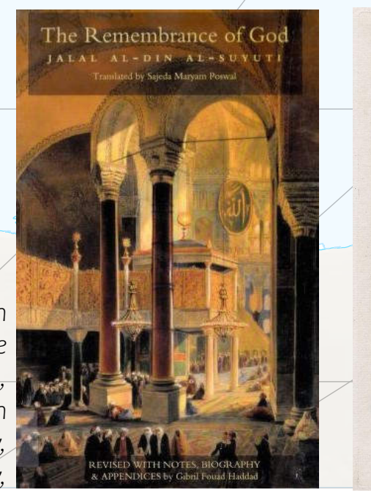
Luca Pacioli is a friar and mathematician in the Italian Papal States. His books, among the first printed in the Italian language, expose ancient Greek and Arabic mathematics to the Rennaissance, along with double-entry bookkeeping (a trade secret among Italian bankers).
< painting by Jacopo de' Barbari, 1495

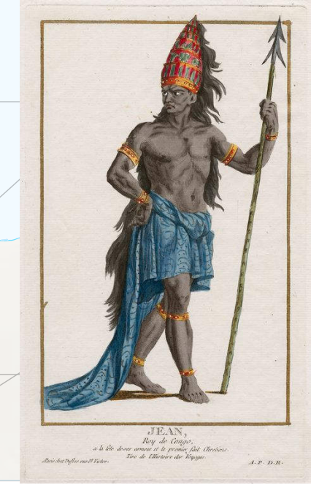
Shen Zhou is a master artist in Suzhou. His personal meditative style of landscape painting will become the Wu School that will be influential in the Ming Dynasty.
"Poetic Feeling of Fallen Flowers" >



Christopher Columbus is spending the Winter of 1492 on Hispaniola with the Taino. Although he is Italian, his Spanish royal sponsors will reap the greatest rewards of his four voyages. while the people of the Americas will reap the worst.
< painting by José María Obregón, 1856

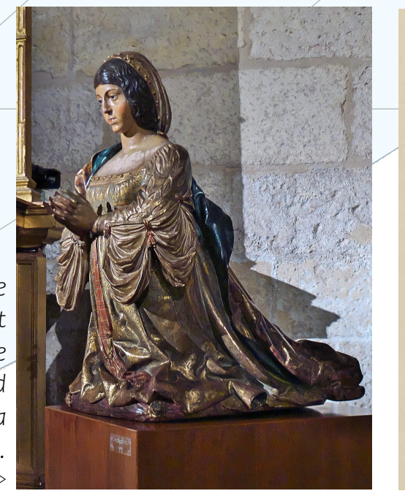
Jalal al-Din al-Suyuti of the Egyptian city of Asyut, is probably the leading Arabic scholar at this time, an expert and prolific writer in Islamic law, linguistics, philosophy, science, and history,

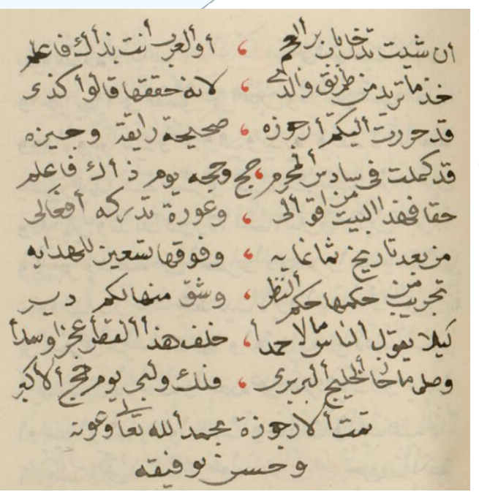




Nzinga a Nkuwu is the King of Congo, who has recently become the first African king (besides Ethiopia) baptized as a Christian in 1491, taking on the name João. That said, he and his subjects continued in their traditional beliefs.
< stylized painting by Pierre Duflos, 1810s

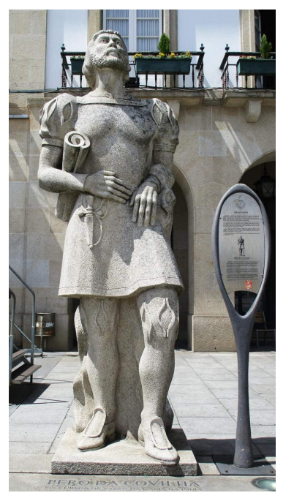
Queen **Isabella of Castille** may be the most powerful woman in the world at this time. She is one of very few female sole monarchs, and with her husband Ferdinand of Aragon is building a Spanish empire as full partners.
1521 sculpture by Felipe Bigarny >





Aḥmad ibn Mājid is an Oman mariner who is best known his handbook of the technology and methods of Sea navigation and the geography of the trade routes of the Indian Ocean.
< poem about the Gulf of Berbera (now Aden)

Although they likely never met...

Pêro da Covilhã has been traveling these same well-established routes, documenting them for future Portuguese explorers and conquerors. He will stay in Ethiopia for the rest of his life.
statue in Covilhã Portugal >